Orazio Gianutio — Libro nel quale si tratta della maniera di giuocar a scacchi (1597)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

This presentation is dedicated to Orazio Gianutio della Mantia, a gentleman of Turin, who offered his chess book to polite players rather than accomplished masters, and dedicated it at Turin, 24 February 1597, to Count Francesco Martinengo di Malpaga. It honours also the correction carried below, a folder claim replaced by the checked record.

The author's own terms

Partiti: his set problems closing the book, each a mate in a stated number of moves, neither more nor less. The king's “leap”: his period castling rule, the unmoved king leaping two or three squares, in Italian and Spanish forms. “Passing battle”: his phrase for *en passant*, which he says is not used in Italy.

The story

Gianutio's life is thinly documented; nothing is invented here to fill it. The folder gives him born in 1565; another tradition gives 1550, with a death about 1610 — neither is settled here. Folder and print record agree on the book alone: Turin, 1597, dedicated to Martinengo as above.

The folder's claim that the book had never been Englished has been corrected, as below; the correction is this story's centre. Soon superseded by Salvio and Carrera, it still reached English readers in 1817 in a form whose title admits arrangement.

The work and what survives

The first edition (Turin: Antonio de Bianchi, 1597) is a quarto with woodcut arms on the title and woodcut illustrations of the pieces and board. The folder file's “Table of the First Book” lists nine items: the rules of the chessmen; beginnings with the King's pawn and with the Queen's pawn; the gambit; four odds chapters, on receiving the King's bishop's pawn with or without the move, a knight without the move, and a knight for that pawn with the move; and, last, the games of draughts. Front matter precedes it; the *partiti* and the knight's tour, numbered 1 to 32, close the book. Christie's cross-checks six openings favoured in Italy, the most space to the Two Knights' Defence; the edition is EDIT16 CNCE 33981, pinned through Lot-Art — the EDIT16 page itself was not opened.

The *partiti* count is unsettled: folder draft, sixteen (the Twelfth, the tour); Christie's, 12 problem woodcuts; an Italian catalogue and a second Christie's, 13 board figures and 11 problems. “32 problems” is unsupported — 32 is the tour's square count.

Its English fortunes

Gianutio's 1597 book was Englished in J. H. Sarratt's *The Works of Gianutio and Gustavus Selenus on the Game of Chess* (London: J. Ebers, 1817, two volumes, “translated and arranged” by J. H. Sarratt). It is a combined work: Selenus is the pen name of August II of Braunschweig-Lüneburg, whose 1616 German book reworks Ruy López, so Selenus matter in Sarratt is not Gianutio. No other English translation of it was found after research in the PIN and collation runs.

Whether Sarratt includes any given part of the 1597 book — openings, odds chapters, *partiti*, knight's tour, draughts chapter — has not been collated item by item: HathiTrust full view returned 403, no Internet Archive copy was established, and no page of Sarratt was opened. No specific omission or

inclusion is claimed.

The verdicts disagree and are carried, not settled, at secondary-source strength, secondaries having been opened rather than Sarratt's pages. Fiske: “so mutilated as to be of little value.” Walker: “barbarously mutilated.” Murray, via his Lewis biography: lacking unity, signs of hasty composition. Hooper and Whyld, the counterweight: too compressed, but nevertheless useful. Unsettled likewise: Sarratt's source language (preface unread) and volume one's pagination (233 or 223 pages).

What completing it would take

The open task is named: open Sarratt's two volumes (HathiTrust record 009706227; the New York Public Library or Harvard copies; or a library or reprint copy) and score the 1597 items above against Sarratt's actual contents pages, Selenus matter attributed to Selenus. Until then, no completeness wording for either version is warranted.

The folder draft — a complete draft rendering from the 1597 Italian, marked draft and local only, not yet through final checks — lost every diagram in its scan; its draughts chapter is unrecoverable there and untranslated; some opening lines are corrupt and bracketed. Completing it takes a woodcut-preserving copy and collation of those passages.

Sources

- Project folder: `~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/gianutio-scacchi-1597/gianutio-scacchi-1597.txt`
- PIN and collation: `~/workspace/packages/boneyard-extension/research/PIN-gianutio.md`; `~/workspace/packages/boneyard-extension/research/SARRATT-COLLATION.md`
- Christie's, 1597 edition: https://www.christies.com/lot/lot-5495287
- Lot-Art (EDIT16 CNCE 33981): https://www.lot-art.com/auction-lots/Chess-Gianutio-Orazio-Libro-nel-quale-si-tratta-della-maniera-di-giuocara/12-che_gianutio-26.3.26-forum
- HathiTrust record 009706227: https://catalog.hathitrust.org/Record/009706227

- Chess.com, Fiske and Walker: https://www.chess.com/blog/batgirl/the-professor-of-chess
- Chess.com, Murray: https://www.chess.com/article/view/19th-century-chess-from-sarratt-to-morphy?page=5
- Chess.com, Hooper and Whyld quoted: https://www.chess.com/it/blog/Franciplus/il-gambetto-italiano
- Knight's tour literature: https://www.mayhematics.com/t/1a.htm